Lesson 03: Grammar: Simple Present, Simple Past and Present Perfect

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 1.4: Grammar Presentation-Simple Present, Simple Past, and Present Perfect Tenses; 1.5: Applying Grammar to Reading; 1.6: Communication Practice; Irregular Verbs.

In this lesson

You will review three tenses that academic texts use all the time: the simple present (facts and theories), the simple past (finished events and studies) and the present perfect (time up to now). You will find them in "The Story Behind Dreams", practise the -ed ending, and write a paragraph that introduces a person.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Use the simple present with correct subject-verb agreement (he/she/it + -s).
- Choose between the simple past and the present perfect by looking at signal words.
- Form the past and past participle of common irregular verbs.
- Identify the tenses in an academic reading.
- Pronounce the -ed ending as /t/, /d/ or /ɪd/.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
simple present	the base form (the verb with no ending), or base form + -s after he/she/it	The Earth rotates on its axis.
third-person singular	he, she, it, or one person or thing	Mika plays video games.
subject-verb agreement	the verb matches its subject (singular or plural)	You play video games.
simple past	a completed action in the past	Yesterday, Victoria went to the bank.
signal word	a word or phrase that tells when something happened	yesterday, three months ago, last week
present perfect	have/has + past participle	Anastasiya has eaten sushi.
past participle	the verb form used after have/has	eaten, written, woken

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
irregular verb	a verb whose past is not made with -ed	go, went, gone

Rules and explanations

Simple present

Use	Example
General facts	The Earth rotates on its axis.
Routines and habits	She practices gratitude every day.
Feelings	He enjoys hiking.
Possessions	Yun-Ji has a car.

Subject-verb agreement

- After a third-person singular subject (he, she, it, or one person or thing), the verb changes: Mika plays video games.
- After I, you, we, they and plural subjects, use the base form: You play video games. Two subjects joined with "and" are plural.
- Three ways to make the he/she/it form:

Rule	Examples
add -s	play → plays
add -es or -ies	miss → misses; study → studies (consonant + y → -ies)
irregular	have → has; do → does

Simple past

- A completed action in the past, often with a signal word: yesterday; [length of time] + ago; last night, week, month, year or a specific day.
- Yesterday, Victoria went to the bank. Three months ago, Ayman visited Los Angeles, California. Last week, we studied paragraphs.

Present perfect

Form	Pattern	Example
affirmative	have/has + past participle	Anastasiya has eaten sushi.
negative	have/has + not + past participle	The package still hasn't arrived.
question	have/has + subject + past participle	Have you ever broken a bone?

The present perfect has five uses:

1. The time of the event is unknown (the action is finished): Anastasiya has eaten sushi.
2. The action started in the past and continues now: Kyaw and Sunil have been friends for several years.
3. The action has been repeated several times: Rafael and Jianhua have been absent many times this semester.
4. An uncompleted action is expected to finish: The package still hasn't arrived.
5. The action happened recently: The children have just woken up.

Simple past or present perfect?

- A finished time is given (yesterday, ago, last ..., in February, when I was a child): use the simple past. NOT: Yesterday, Victoria has gone to the bank.
- No time, or time up to now (for, since, so far, this week, ever, already, just, still): use the present perfect.

Irregular verbs

Learn them in the book's groups (base form, past, past participle):

Group	Pattern	Examples
1	all three the same	cut, cut, cut; put, put, put
2	i, a, u	sing, sang, sung; swim, swam, swum
3	-ew, -own	know, knew, known; fly, flew, flown
4	-ought, -aught	think, thought, thought; teach, taught, taught
5 and 6	participle with -en	write, wrote, written; break, broke, broken
7	d becomes t	send, sent, sent; build, built, built
8	past = participle	pay, paid, paid; keep, kept, kept

The book's table has three printing mistakes: bring, brought, brought, **bringing** (not "brining"); forgive, forgave, **forgiven** (not "forgiving"); tell, **told**, told (not "sold").

Pronunciation of -ed

Sound	When	Examples
/t/	after the voiceless sounds /p/ /k/ /f/ /s/ /ʃ/ /tʃ/	shopped, baked, laughed, kissed, pushed, punched
/d/	after voiced sounds (/b/ /g/ /v/ /z/ /m/ /n/ /l/ /r/ /ŋ/ /ð/ /ʒ/ /dʒ/) and after all vowel sounds	robbed, loved, prayed, used, called, changed
/ɪd/	after /t/ and /d/; it adds a syllable	needed, wanted

A voiced sound makes your vocal cords vibrate; a voiceless sound does not. To test a sound, put your hand on your throat: if you feel a vibration, the sound is voiced.

Note for Arabic speakers

- Arabic has no present perfect form, so it is easy to use the simple past or present for a situation that continues now ("I live here since 2020"). In English, use have/has + past participle: Kyaw and Sunil have been friends for several years.
- Arabic has no /p/ sound. Say /p/ clearly in shopped, and remember that /p/ is voiceless, so the ending is /t/: shopped /t/.

Practice

Exercise 4. Subject-verb agreement. Select the appropriate verb form.

1. Shpresa _____ letters to her boyfriend during class. a) write b) writes
2. We _____ to register for classes before the deadline. a) have b) has
3. Merita and Besart _____ to give their presentation first. a) want b) wants
4. You _____ very well. The food is delicious! a) cook b) cooks
5. Issra _____ her homework immediately after class. a) do b) does
6. I _____ by practicing the concepts many times. a) learn b) learns
7. Ivana's book _____ a lot. a) weigh b) weighs
8. The flowers _____ beautiful! a) smell b) smells
9. Alamdar _____ twins. a) have b) has
10. Yulee _____ French. a) study b) studies

Exercise 6. Simple present or present perfect? (The choices are the simple past and the present perfect. In item 4 the book prints "three time"; it should be "three times".)

1. Katayoon is a writer. She _____ many books. a) wrote b) has written
2. Njomza is a teacher. Last semester, she _____ our algebra class. a) taught b) has taught
3. Lina and Andrius _____ in the classroom since 8:00 AM. a) were b) have been
4. Zaire's phone _____ class three times already. a) interrupted b) has interrupted
5. Abena _____ on a rollercoaster. She loves adventure! a) rode b) has ridden
6. Xuan and Wen _____ the teacher's office after class so that they can better understand the topics covered during the lecture. a) visited b) have visited
7. Aida _____ her project two weeks ago. a) finished b) has finished
8. Naoko _____ her project. a) finished b) has just finished
9. Ravneet _____ her boss five times. She wants to tell her boss that she will be absent at work today. a) called b) has called
10. Yara _____ two exams, an essay, and a presentation so far this week. a) had b) has had
11. When I was a child, I _____ every day during the summer. a) swam b) have swum
12. Since I was a child, I _____ an interest in learning. a) had b) have had
13. Which cities _____? a) did you visit b) have you visited

14. I _____ to San Francisco last month and Sacramento in February. a) went b) have gone

Exercise 8. Verb tense review. Notice the signal words. In some cases, two answers are possible.

1. I _____ [live] in Mexico when I was a child. a) live b) lived c) have lived
2. My parents _____ [live] in California. a) live b) lived c) have lived
3. The students _____ [do] a grammar exercise every day this week. a) do b) did c) have done
4. Noor _____ [just/find] $20. a) just finds b) just found c) has just found
5. My family _____ [go] on vacation once a year. a) goes b) went c) has gone
6. I _____ [take] four classes last semester. a) take b) took c) have taken
7. My best friend _____ [send] me letters regularly. a) sends b) sent c) has sent
8. Last night, I _____ [do] my homework between 9:30 and 11 pm. a) do b) did c) have done
9. My brother _____ [go] to the park with his daughter. a) goes b) went c) has gone
10. We _____ [love] to study grammar! a) love b) loved c) have loved

Exercise 9. Error analysis. Correct the errors.

1. Balkaran has visited his uncle yesterday.
2. Preet studied every morning before his class begins.
3. Laila cooks lunch last Sunday.
4. The college offers ESL classes on Saturdays, but now it didn't.
5. José studied at Reedley College for three semesters. Next semester, he will transfer.

Exercise 10. Identifying verb tenses. Reread paragraphs 1-3 of "The Story Behind Dreams" (lesson material, section 1.5). Write the verbs in three lists: simple present, simple past, present perfect. Examples: walk, believed, have tried. Leave out verbs with can, might or would, and be + -ing forms (were dreaming).

Exercise 11. Pronunciation of simple past verbs. Reread paragraphs 7-9 (section 1.5). Find the simple past verbs and sort them by sound: /t/, /d/, /ɪd/ or irregular. Examples: rushed /t/, proved /d/, provided /ɪd/, were (irregular).

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me the questions from Exercise 3 (simple present), Exercise 5 (simple past) and Exercise 7 (present perfect). Stop me every time I use the wrong tense or forget an -s ending."
- "Exercise 12: ask me the four questions, and I will answer as Partner 1 and then as Partner 2 from the profiles in section 1.6. Then I will report each partner's answers (Partner 1 exercises every day)."
- "Play a new classmate. I will interview you about your country, city, classes, how long you have studied English and your hobbies."

Read aloud

1. Mika plays /z/ video games, and Yulee studies /z/ French.

2. Three months ago, Ayman visited /ɪd/ Los Angeles, California.
3. Last week, we studied /d/ paragraphs.
4. The package still hasn't arrived /d/.
5. Laila cooked /t/ lunch last Sunday.
6. These scientists provided /ɪd/ a group of people with a difficult-to-solve maze.

Writing task

Introduce a person (Exercise 13). After your interview with your tutor (see Speak with your tutor), write a paragraph of 120 to 160 words that introduces this "classmate" to a new class, or introduce yourself in the third person (He is from ...). Include: name, country of origin, current city, arrival in this city, classes this semester, previous classes, length of time studying English, hobbies and interests. Use the simple present for the situation now, the simple past for finished events with a time, and the present perfect with for or since.

Checklist:

- Every simple present verb after he, she or a name has -s, -es or -ies.
- Every finished time (ago, last ..., in 2020) has a simple past verb, never the present perfect.
- I used the present perfect with for or since for situations that continue now.
- I checked my irregular verbs in the table (took, began, spent).
- My first sentence introduces the person, and my last sentence closes the paragraph.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Verb Tenses: Simple Present: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Vyls_R3n1Cw
- Verb Tenses: Simple Past: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0W8nKdeBE9w
- Verb Tenses: Present Perfect: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pMG9Yyr8kfU

Answer key

Exercise 4 (all book): 1. b) writes 2. a) have 3. a) want 4. a) cook 5. b) does 6. a) learn 7. b) weighs 8. a) smell 9. b) has 10. b) studies. (In item 8 the book prints "smell" twice by mistake.)

Exercise 6 (all book)

1. b) has written 2. a) taught 3. b) have been 4. b) has interrupted 5. b) has ridden
6. a) visited. b) have visited is also possible if you mean that they have done this several times up to now.
7. a) finished 8. b) has just finished 9. b) has called 10. b) has had 11. a) swam 12. b) have had
13. b) have you visited. a) did you visit is also correct when you ask about one finished trip.
14. a) went

Exercise 8

1. b) lived (book) 2. a) live (book) 3. c) have done (book)
4. c) has just found (book). b) just found is also correct, especially in American English.
5. a) goes (the book's key says c) has gone; this is a mistake because "once a year" shows a habit, and habits take the simple present).
6. b) took (book) 7. a) sends (book) 8. b) did (book)
9. c) has gone (book): he is at the park now. Because there is no signal word, a) goes (a habit) and b) went (a finished event) are also correct.
10. a) love (book)

Exercise 9 (book)

1. Balkaran visited his uncle yesterday.
2. Preet studies every morning before his class begins.
3. Laila cooked lunch last Sunday.
4. The college offered ESL classes on Saturdays, but now it doesn't.
5. José has studied at Reedley College for three semesters. Next semester, he will transfer.

Exercise 10

- Simple present (book): walk, realize, start(s), make(s), leave, turn, realize, wake up, are, aren't, is ('s), dream, believe, do (forget), point out. Also in the text: have ("why we have dreams") and involve ("our dreams so often involve stressful events"); the book's key leaves them out.
- Simple past (book): believed (three times), were, showed, centered, wanted, called. Also in paragraph 1: forgot and moved; the book's key leaves them out.
- Present perfect (book): have tried ('ve tried), have emerged, have ever seen ('ve ever seen).

Exercise 11

- /t/: rushed (book)
- /d/: proved, allowed, returned, performed, considered, recalled (book)

- /ɪd/: provided, reported (book)
- Irregular: were, said, woke up, spent, put down, went, taught (book). Also came ("the idea … came to him in a dream"); the book's key leaves it out.
- Note: in "have also long been considered" and "still taught in schools today", considered and taught are past participles, not simple past verbs. Their pronunciation is the same.

My notes